

Old versions

If for any reason, you prefer older versions of software, head over to www.oldversion.com

Bullet-point engineering

The process of looking at competitor's feature list and incorporating them in the developer's own feature list

Feature

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Bloatware is a dirty word bandied about below the noses of commercial software development companies, mostly by users who prefer modularity over comprehensiveness. To understand what exactly bloatware is, it is necessary to peek into the production process of software. Software is a lot of code compiled together, and run as an application. The code itself is often written by many people, over a code skeleton. This process is known as development. Software, in active development, has a release

timeline, a list of improvements, bug fixes and new features. The consecutive releases of the software are called versions. As the versions increase, the amount of aggregated code in the software also increases along with the file size. Consider the popular video player – VLC 0.8.2: the first version to be released to the public, started as a 1.7 MB download. The latest installation, VLC 0.9.8 is 15.8 MB!

Why software bloats

Every modern commercial software, has a bunch of mainstay elements. Even for free software such as Adobe Reader, there are just too many features being included in

subsequent releases. Winamp and VLC, are both commonly used media playback software, and have advanced features that is not of use to everyone. Feature bloat is just one kind of bloatware. Games, and professional multimedia processing software include code for handling copy protection, and ensuring that the software is licensed and authenticated. Adobe Photoshop and Premiere both struggle on even on the best rigs available in the market.

Then there is process bloat. For example, the latest version of Winamp runs both an agent as well as the player itself. These are two processes for essentially the same task. Printers, soundcards, and routers often come with CDs that install software on the computer, that are not really necessary. These software perform essentially the same task as the OS, but with little added functionality, and a better looking user interface. Another kind of bloat is almost opposite to that of feature bloat. There are multiple software installed in a system, for essentially the same, or similar tasks.

Quicktime and RealPlayer are players for their native formats, and both the media players suffer from feature bloat as well. Often users have to install multiple browsers on their operating systems, even if they need and use just one. This happens for two reasons – firstly; until Windows 7, it was not possible to uninstall Internet Explorer. Secondly, not all web sites could be viewed on all browsers. A user will typically have a download manager, a P2P client and a torrent client, when a single

BLOATWARE

Replacements

Get rid of all the resource hogging software that you use, and replace them with streamlined applications that use system resources only when you need them to.



Illustration: Chaitanya Surpur